

Hollerbier Haven

Newsletter for Herbal and Healing Arts



The Growing of a Guild

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Hollerbier Haven is a collaborative effort of two herbalists who share a passion for the preservation of traditional healing arts and herbal medicine.

Susan Hess graduated from the Herbal Therapeutics School of Botanical Medicine in 1996. She is a Therapeutic Herbalist, an herbal educator and has maintained a thriving herbal products business, Farm at Coventry, since 1997. She is currently training in the Pennsylvania German healing arts tradition.

Jesse Tobin graduated from the Herbal Therapeutics School of Botanical Medicine in 2006. She has a bachelor's degree in Healing

Arts from Prescott College, and over the past five years Jesse has studied in the traditional Pennsylvania German healing practice known as Braucherei (or Powwow). After training with several different practitioners, she is now compiling a book on the Braucherei tradition. Jesse is a practicing Herbalist and Braucher, as well as a teacher in traditional Pennsylvania German healing arts.

We have joined together through a common love of traditional healing methods for the body and soul. It is through this fond association that we have dedicated ourselves and our work to the creation of a new educational endeavor.

The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts holds the revival of Braucherei wisdom at the heart of its mission. We seek to honor and revive the spiritual, folk medical, and agricultural wisdom of the Pennsylvania German people. We are dedicated to returning this cultural inheritance in its most whole and inspired form to its heirs. We recognize the culture and tradition of the Pennsylvania Germans as a living being, and seek to sustain and grow its spirit. We honor the traditions of elders yet also remain open to the continuing evolution of the culture.

This newsletter, Hollerbier Haven is a first publication of the Three Sisters Center. (cont'd page 3)

Hollerbier Fraa

Hollerbier is the Pennsylvania German word for the elderberry bush. In English we call her "elder" because of her grandmother spirit. She is sometimes gentle, sometimes stern, but always wise. The German name for

elder, Hollerbier, comes from the ancient Germanic goddess who is alternately: Hulda, Holle, Frau Holle, Mother Holle, etc. She has a decidedly crone character, and was revered as the guardian of the dead. In Germanic, Slavic, and

Celtic countries she was known to help the dead in crossing over. She was also known to help the living in communication with deceased relatives. In the ancient myths she is responsible for receiving the (cont'd on page 2)

Hollerbier Fraa

(Continued from page 1) souls of the dead, and for releasing the souls of the unborn from the underworld so they can be born again.

Her story is almost identical to that of Baba Yaga in Russian Mythology and folk culture. She is thought to live in an enchanted mill at the bottom of a well, where she grinds the souls of old men and women back to dust so they can be born anew.

In Christian times the church was unable to force the Germanic people to abandon their beloved mother Holle. Instead they allowed her to live on as the 'queen of the witches', implying that those who continued to honor her were witches themselves.

The energies of Hollerbier Fraa are most powerful during the darkest part of the year: that of the yuletide, or the days surrounding the winter solstice. In folk cultural beliefs she would ride during this time at the forefront of the wild hunt, leading a host of spirits behind her. Despite the determined efforts of the church, however, Frau Holle would not be demonized so easily.

Unlike many of the plants associated with witchcraft, elder is thought to be a friendly spirit who likes people and wants to help them. Elders were especially well known for warding off black magic. All manner of personal affects such as hair, nail clippings, clothes, placentas, etc, were buried beneath the elder so she would keep the owner safe from harm.

In the Grimm brother's depiction of Mother Holle, they showed how those who honor this great and wise old spirit, those who come by fruitful harvests in life in due course and by honest work, are gifted with plenty. Those who are lazy and would prefer to cheat their way to wealth and power, however, do not fool this wise elder, and she gives them exactly the rewards they have earned.

In modern Braucherei practices Hollerbier Fraa continues to be revered as one of our most important guides. Her physical medicine is used for people of all ages for colds, flu, coughs, sore throats, allergies, fevers, etc. and used in a variety of "sympathies" in Braucherei.



Her medicine is so tasty that any child will take it quite willingly, and her wood, flowers and berries are used to make a variety of remedies.

Her spirit is called upon for guidance in time cord work. In the spiritual realms she is the great translator, able to transform the most indecipherable teachings into understandable lessons and guidance. She helps those who seek transformation to pass through the death and rebirth cycle and flower into their new form.



Elder Berry Cordial

Combine One Quart Fresh Elderberries, stems removed with one cup water.

Simmer over low heat for 40 min. until berries release their juices with the help of a good potato masher.

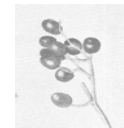
Strain pulp and seeds from hot berry juice and return to a clean pot.

Add one teaspoon whole ginger root and whole cloves. Simmer 15 minutes and strain again.

Measure the amount of spicy elderberry infusion then add an equal part honey and a half part good brandy.

Stir until the honey melts and is incorporated well with the juice and brandy. Allow to cool completely.

Bottle and store in the refrigerator until it can be enjoyed on the first chilly night in the fall.....



The Growing of a Guild (cont'd)

(Continued from page 1) The quarterly newsletter will include articles on herbal, seasonal, astrological or historical information and folklore along with traditional Braucherei wisdom. It will also contain seasonal recipes and a current calendar of Guild meetings and Three Sisters Center workshops.

As we delve deeper into the traditional practices of Pennsylvania German people we hope to share our gleanings with all of you. We have created this newsletter to share our research, as well as our vision, with the wider community.

It is with this same intention that we invite you to become a member of the

Hollerbier Haven Herbal and Healing Arts Guild.

In addition to receiving our quarterly newsletter, other member benefits would include: early notification and member discounts on monthly gatherings of the Guild and seasonal workshops of the Three Sisters Center. The Guild Gatherings would tentatively occur the last Saturday of each month and other full day workshops would be held seasonally.

Guild Gatherings will offer a wide variety of short lecture topics but also include seasonal celebrations and foods, herbal crafts, and discussions on traditional healing techniques and Braucherei Wisdom.

We hope that out of this newsletter we can create a community of others dedicated to the revival and embodiment of traditional wisdom of wholeness as it relates to our bodies and souls, and that of the earth we walk upon. Join us.....

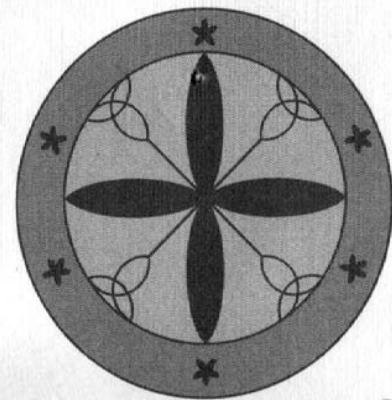


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The Ones Who Dreamed

(The following is a traditional story told by an elder from Snyder County, Pennsylvania)

“Long ago there was a woman who became the first person to use powwow. She came from a people who were our early ancestors, the ones who lived closer to nature, learned to use things from nature. She was a little different than the others, and the others sensed that, even when she was a girl. When it was her time to become a woman, she went through a change that none before had experienced: that night she dreamt the first dream that any person had dreamt. When she woke up she told the first dream story that had ever been told. The people were amazed, and thought this was a miracle. Even though the woman was young, she soon came to be seen as the vessel for new knowledge to come to the people. She continued to dream with this

In dreams she saw the animals and sent the hunters to find them. In dreams she saw the plants that would cure sickness. In dreams she saw the answers to prayers. In dreams she could hear the truthful voice of the heart and soul. As she dreamed her dreams, she gathered power. Her dreams taught her to have dreams while awake. Her dreams taught her to find dreamlands in many places. Her dreams taught her how to teach others how to dream, and the people again knew that they had a miracle among them. So the sacred life came from the early people. All the medicine, magic, song, and stories that came after that came out of those dreams. When those who follow the sacred path talk with people of that time, they call them ‘the people who dreamed’.

The Braucherei Tradition

The Braucherei tradition has been called a “magico-religious folk medical” tradition. This description is true, but not complete. The word *Braucherei* in the Pennsylvania German dialect holds many meanings. The Pennsylvania German verb *brauche* can mean “to need” or “to be of necessity”, “to use”, or “to try.” In High German form- from which this term was derived- *ein Brauch* is a tradition - any tradition, or an heirloom — something special or sacred to a family that is passed down for generations. The verb *brauchen* in High German is used identically with its Pennsylvania German usage.

When all of these meanings are combined the spectrum of Braucherei becomes clear. It is the heirloom of the German people, the necessary practice, the traditional knowledge of the use of energy (or spirit) to heal and make whole.

A Braucher, Brauchdocktor, Braucherin, or Brauchfraa is a practitioner of the Braucherei tradition. The Braucher does not claim responsibility for the efficacy of his or her prayers. They believe that the individual person and the Holy Spirit are the two beings responsible in the act of healing. The Braucher is only a facilitator, a teacher, a channel. The Braucher can only “try” by opening themselves to act as a conduit through which the Holy Spirit may come.

In Southeastern Pennsylvania, Brauchers were once as common as churches. They served their communities in a very similar way: the Braucher, being in the service of God, was required to “try” for anyone when asked. They generally did not require payment, though it was generally given. Payment was sometimes in the form of

money, but could be a wide variety of other products or services, or in the case of a very poor person, nothing at all.

Most Brauchers were also doctors, herbalists, midwives, or veterinarians. There were few who kept strictly to Braucherei itself. Often Brauchers were called upon in everyday matters such as the creation of a hex sign, or the placement of a building. In matters of the supernatural, Brauchers were called upon to calm disruptive ghosts, or to help spirits cross over to the other side.

Though the tradition has become significantly fragmented since the early 20th century, it is slowly reviving. Through the work of several scholars the tradition is being carefully pieced together from its fractured form. Missing pieces are being researched and lovingly restored. A compendium of knowledge and folk wisdom is revealing its face, a face that is as old as its people, yet vital and brilliant when seen.

The recovered knowledge includes healing techniques ranging from medicinal herbs, charms, and amulets to energy work, prayer, and shamanic healing. It includes ceremonial information, sweat lodge practices, seasonal and agricultural traditions, and theories of medicine and magic. The list goes on and on, but most importantly this tradition holds the knowledge and wisdom of a people that have endured. The information kept alive and sacred by the Brauchers is knowledge that has been under attack since the times of the Romans. The wisdom traditions of the German people have endured despite near constant assault because they were essential- essential to the wholeness of individuals and that of the entire culture.



Moon Tides: Planting Seeds-For Soil and Soul



For centuries, moon-wise gardeners have observed many outward expressions of fertility and fullness during the waxing of the moon (the two weeks of the lunar cycle when the moon grows from new to full). The sap rises in the tree, blossoms burst open and fruits swell, increasing in size and sweetness.

Play close attention and you will witness the earth exhale and breathe life force to all that is growing above the ground. The new moon brings forth the finest 'seed potential' and the promise of germination and new growth.

A glance through the farmer's almanac reminds us that planting by the moon reconnects us to the rhythms of the heavens. "Plant above annual ground vegetable plants, herbs and flowers from the new moon through the second quarter."

A thoughtful gardener knows that seed planting requires the garden site to be properly prepared. Soil needs to be loosened and unwanted debris, stones and weeds removed. Compost and manure are added for nourishment of the future seedlings.

In this way, we consciously prepare a space for our seeds and invite them to flourish after they have been lovingly pushed into the ground. If we are fortunate, the heavens reward our efforts with rain and sunshine.

So, too, should we consciously prepare our own 'inner' garden space in the days leading up to the new moon phase. By anticipating and preparing for the monthly return of the invisible moon, when the sky is a dark, rich fertile field, we are inviting our intuition to whisper the seeds and using the moon's fertile energy to blow sweet life into them.

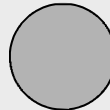
By being conscious, instinctual, open and receptive during the time of the new moon and waxing phase that leads us up to the full moon, we can cultivate our own worthwhile seeds... and then aspire to grow them.

The new moon sends us a monthly invitation to dig in with both hands, prune, weed and plant our soul gardens. Tending it and giving it the nourishment it needs will keep our lives moving towards a rich and meaningful harvest.



- **May New Moon: May 16th**
- **June New Moon: June 14th**
- **July New Moon: July 14th**

Such a slender moon, going up and up,
Waxing so fast from night to night,
And swelling like an orange flower-bud,
bright, fated, me thought,
to round as a golden cup,
And hold to my two lips
life's best of wine.



-Jean Ingelow





Walpurgis Nacht



The festival of May Eve has many names. This feast, beginning with the moon rise on the night before May 1st, was celebrated across Europe as Beltane, May Eve, Floralia, Roodmas, etc. The peoples of Europe used the energies of May Eve to enhance fertility among themselves, for their crops, and in their animals. Bonfires celebrated the strengthening sun, and were used to purify human and animal populations.

To the Germans May Eve was called Walpurgis Nacht. In addition to the fertility rites of spring, this day was used for rituals performed to evade the forces of winter and the wild hunt. Walpurgis was also called "Lady Summer" and the May first feasts welcomed her in. For nine days before the feast of May 1st, the Wild Hunt (led by Holle and Woden), pursued her and during this time villagers would leave their windows and doors open to give her refuge.

In later times, the holiday became St. Walpurgis Dag, after the Catholic St. Walburga, Abbess of Heidenheim. When the church took on May 1st as an official feast day, the revelry the night before became focused on driving out the forces of paganism, instead of those of winter. Holle and Woden and their wild hunt became the leaders of a witch cult, and the Brocken, once one of the most holy places in the Germanic landscape (sacred to the Goddess Freya), became the place of convergence of all the German witches.

The stories we have been handed down in the Braucherei tradition, as per usual, are a blend of pre-Christian, Christian, and new world belief. Walpurga, the goddess, was depicted as a lady in white holding a spindle and a three-pointed mirror. Walburga, the saint, looks almost identical. Both the saint and the goddess were thought to protect against evil magic, famine, disease, crop failures and the bites of rabid dogs. Brauchers (and quite possibly, many PA German people in the hills and valleys of eastern Pennsylvania) would write "Walpurgis" above the door on Walpurgis Nacht to fend off the last desperate forces of winter, disease, and famine; and also to invite the lady of summer to stay, bringing her gifts of plenty.

Festivities in Pennsylvania continued to include the traditions of bonfires, tricks, blessings, and noise (to scare off the spirits of winter and the forces of evil).

Some of these spirits of winter and famine were named. There were three frost spirits called "Dreizeh Dachs", "Fatzeh Fadder", and "Fuffzeh Fooks". It was because of these frost spirits that elders taught to plant after the 15th of May.

In Pennsylvania, the Germans developed a calendar of moons,

which corresponded to the twelve moons of astrology, but also carried the powers of new world animals. The moon that corresponds to Taurus, and presides over the May Eve festivities is the Holzent Muun (Woodduck Moon). The Holzent teaches the need for balance and unification of the male and female energies. She unites Earth, Air, and Water. Offerings made on Walpurgis Nacht were often made in the hollow of a tree in honor of the Holzent and her teachings.

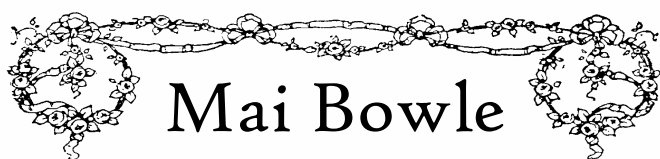
In Braucherei there are four birds of power. One of them, the Sonnadler (Sun Eagle), rules over this time of the year. His energies are that of empowerment, and guiding the young Braucher on his or her path to understanding of, and competence in the traditional ways. His energies of empowerment extend beyond this reach, however. He calls out to all people to find empowerment within themselves, to connect to the energies of the Holy Spirit, finding harmony there, and to manifest with integrity that which you strive for in life.



The energies of Walpurgis Nacht encourage us to find some aspect of our lives which we wish to grow. Grow some aspect of your spirit, your work, your connection with others, or simply your garden. This is a time to solidify your intentions for growth, for at Sonnenwenden, the sun turns and the energies turn to decline, harvest, and removing the outmoded ways of your past.

The ways of tradition are handed down to guide us, and to inform us of the energies present during different times. These rhythms are rhythms that have been honored and understood for millennia. I invite you to take what you can from the ways of the elders, and find your own understanding, your own way, your own bliss.

Many blessings on your Walpurgis Nacht, and may your gardens grow green.



Mai Bowle

Blend well and allow to steep overnight:

*1 large bottle white German wine (Rhine)

*1 cup sliced fresh strawberries

*12 sprigs of sweet woodruff, chopped well

Strain. Pour into punch bowl and add:

* 1/2 cup super fine sugar. Stir until dissolved.

Chill thoroughly. Just before serving add:

*1 bottle chilled champagne, sparkling wine,
sparkling cider or ginger ale

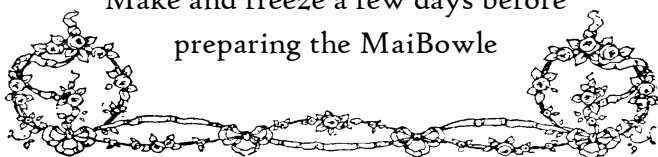
*fresh sliced strawberries

*fresh sprigs of woodruff

In Germany, this traditional beverage is served not only on May first, but every day in May!

To make the MaiBowle even more festive, float a lovely floral ice ring in the punch bowl. You may use violets, dandelions, or Johnny-jump-ups.

Make and freeze a few days before preparing the MaiBowle



Strawberries and their leaves have been considered to contain spiritual and healing properties for thousands of years. The color of the strawberry was thought to be very important. Using red wool, string or cloth to bind on healing herbs is an ancient custom. The association of red with healing is still manifest today in the name and symbol of the

Red Cross

HOLLERBIER Herbal and Healing Arts Guild

GUIDING PRINCIPLES

The purpose of the Hollerbier Guild is to create a wider circle of friends who acknowledge the essential value of preserving traditional healing methods and who seek to honor and sustain them through personal and group endeavors.

PHILOSOPHY

We recognize.....

- the traditional wisdom and healing practices of our elders, with an emphasis on the rich cultural heritage of Pennsylvania and the people who settled here
- the essential worth of sustainable cultivation, conscious wild-crafting and harvesting plants with gratitude, in all efforts, small and large
- the many gifts of wild, native and cultivated plants and their contributions to the physical and spiritual well-being of the generations before us

We endeavor....

- to keep this traditional knowledge alive and vital through education, seasonal activities and a commitment to further exploration, research and sharing

\$25 per year membership includes:

-Quarterly Guild Journal/Newsletter

-Early notification of all events and discounted fees for Guild Gatherings

Look for a future website/blog that will be linked to
www.FarmatCoventry.com

See Page 13 for more details.....

Sonnenwenden

The Summer Solstice (June 21st) is the time to listen for woodpecker sounds and signs. The woodpecker's presence is a welcome sign of resourcefulness and persistence, and farmers should be careful not to cut down the nesting tree of this bird. The Schpeecht Muun (Woodpecker Moon) brings the apex of the solar year. The sun is at the height of its strength. The green man wanders the world and it blossoms and fruits in his wake. The ancient Germans, as I have said above, called this day "Sonnenwenden" (turning of the sun). As with all of the eight high days of the European calendar, this day was celebrated with fire in the form of bonfires. However, this is a day celebrated with water as well.

Ritual baths, often taken with the water of sacred springs were used to purify, preparing for the waning of the year, and bonfires were built on the edges of lakes, streams, and oceans to signify this balance. The father energy of the sun is great and powerful. It is the life-giving warmth that allows for the growth of the green world. Without the balancing mother energy of the rains that fall down upon the earth as well, the green world would dry up and be burnt to a crisp. Likewise, if the mother's waters fall down too long, and no warmth or light can shine through her clouds, the green world drowns and rots, falling to the world of decay when it should be at its apex.

It is this balance that is celebrated on the day of the solstice. This knowledge of balance, and the dual baptism of fire and water is a constant theme in the Braucherei tradition. For it is around these sacred energies that the green world revolves, and with the green world goes the world of the healer. This is a solar holiday, and so it is



The Willow Lodge seeks to find the balance of male and female-fire and water. It is a place for healers to share and exchange their knowledge. The willow lodge is performed on all of the solar holidays by both male and female braucherei.

Those medicine plants most used for their green growing bodies or sometimes their flowers, and not for their roots or fruits, were often gathered at this time of Sonnenwenden. Healers would harvest them at midnight, or when the first dew formed on their leaves. Some plants that were used for magical purposes were only to be picked on this night.

With regard to planetary magic, this is the end of the creation cycle, in which the spells cast should mimic the sun as it grows. This is a time to find resolution of these prayers and spells, which were put into motion six months ago. Now is not the time for great action, but instead for reflection on the changes and growths of the last six months. Now is time to turn the attention to the destructive cycle, time to look deeply at those behaviors and choices, which have become outmoded, time to turn like the sun to the waning of these things, allowing them to mimic the sun on its journey into darkness.

Sonnenwenden Ritual Bath

On the day when the sun shines on us the longest, lovingly gather flower petals and flowering herbs from your garden or yard early in the morning while they are still wet with dew. Crush the leaves and petals to release their fragrant oils, stuff into a large glass jar and cover with spring or rain water. Allow to infuse in the sun for the entire day until the sun goes down in the evening. Strain the herbs and flowers from the flower/herb sun tea and add this lovely infusion into your bath water in the dark of evening adding fresh flowers to float on the surface of the water.

*This recipe is greatly inspired by the book "Spiritual Bathing- Healing Rituals and Traditions from Around the World" by Rosita Arvigo and Nadine Epstein- Beautiful Book!

Calling Men to the Powwow Path

Article by Matthew Sicher, Braucher

One of the inspiring and revealing facts about the practice of Powwow or Braucherei is that it must be passed on by cross-gender transmission. When teaching another, a man must teach a woman, and a woman must teach a man. This tradition endured for centuries despite the fact that Pennsylvania Germans and their German ancestors had clearly defined gender roles and expectations. The endurance of this aspect of the tradition shows the importance of maintaining a gender balance when walking any medicine path. In Braucherei, healing crosses many cultural boundaries, showing that in healing the focus is to make whole, not to divide.

One of the purposes of the cross-gender transmission is the balancing of the energies of the sexes in the practice and continuation of Braucherei. This way of passing on the tradition exists so that neither sex can dominate the practice. This being the case, one would assume that there are nearly equal amounts of male and female practitioners on the Braucherei path. Unfortunately, this is not so. There are much higher numbers of female Brauchers than males.

Among the Brauchers found and interviewed by myself, my wife, and her teacher, Dennis Boyer, female Brauchers outnumbered males significantly, perhaps only a quarter of the total practitioners being male. In general it also seems as though female practitioners are more visibly active, more willing to share their practice, and more likely to be applying and adding to their powwow practice. I have heard of male practitioners, but none have been willing to talk to me personally about the practice, and few would speak with my wife's teacher, Dennis. Unfortunately this has been my experience in many aspects of life. Men seem often hesitant address issues of spiritual practice, a topic of great emotional vulnerability.

I must voice that I too deeply value a degree of solitude in my spiritual practice. Even with my commitment to keeping Powwow alive and valuable to the lives of ourselves and our descendants, I find that most of my medicine work does not take place with other people. When I am asked to powwow someone, I am happy to do so, having

experienced the power and grace of the powwow prayers and other medicine techniques we have been given. I am grateful to help others to share in these experiences. I still deeply value and need the solo aspects of the practice, however, in order to maintain my vitality and deepen my understanding.

So I write here in connection with all men who have practiced powwow with integrity, and I reach out to any men who have yet to do so. Our teachers for countless generations have insisted on the balancing of the sexes for good reason. When we are born into this world as men, we are immediately endowed with unique and powerful gifts to contribute to in all spheres of the world.

The Braucherei path encourages us all to strive to live our lives in harmony with the Holy Spirit. So to all men who are prepared, walk with humble integrity in the footsteps laid out before you by the Holy Spirit. Consciously embody the medicine wisdom of your people so that your grandsons have rich traditions upon which to stand. The world needs more men of integrity. We need you here and now.





Hosted by Farm at Coventry

Fairy Summer Camp for Children

June 18-22, 2007

- * Storytelling and songs
- * Herb and flower crafts
- * Plant dyeing
- * Dream pillows
- * Identifying boo-boo herbs
- * Making herbal sun teas
- * Making fruit & flower jam
- * Flower foot bath and lip balm

Join Susan Hess
& Jesse Tobin
as they share their
herbal knowledge
for fun and pleasure
on the Farm !!

Monday through Friday 9-1 Cost \$100

Register early! Space is limited to twelve children ages 8 to 12 years old

Hey Mom, please feel free to join us in the gardens, too, if you like !

Questions? Call Susan Hess at Farm at Coventry 1333 Ridge Road
Pottstown, PA 19465 610-469-9591 Or call Jesse at 484-336-4611
Email us at Thr3Sisters@AOL.com





COMMON ELDER

Sambucus nigra

Lady elder, black elder, Hollunder,

Frau Holle

Interesting Historical Facts and Folklore:

Called 'the medicine chest of the country people' the elder is considered sacred to the ancient spiritual traditions of the Celtic, Germanic and Norse peoples.

In it's branches was believed to dwell a tree spirit: an Elder Mother, or in Germany, Frau Holle. If planted, or growing close to the entryway of a home, it was believed that the tree would ward off evil and be a source of protection for those that dwelled there. In return, permission to cut the elder wood, or to harvest the flowers or berries must always be asked. There is another old belief that whoever stood under an elder on Midsummer's Eve would see the king of the fairies and other fairy folk.

References:

Herbalpedia- Maureen Rogers at the The Herb Growing & Marketing Network @ Herbworld.com

****Herbal Therapeutics- Specific Indications**

David Winston www.Herbaltherapeutics.com

A Modern Herbal- Mrs. M. Grieve (1931)

Where and when to gather: Native elders are a small bushy tree that produces many small trunks from it's base. The creamy white elder flowers bloom in June and are produced on dinner plate sized umbels. Harvest the entire umbel on a dry sunny morning after the dew has dried. The stems and flower stalks should be removed after the flowers have dried. The berries arrive in August and are picked when they are dark purple to black in appearance. Do not ingest unripe red berries, leaves or bark and berries. Elders prefer to grow in damp areas in partial shade, but also will grow in full sun. Before you plant one in your garden, be aware that a happy elder can grow to be over 15 feet high!

Traditional medicinal uses:

The dried flowers reduce phlegm while also toning the mucus membranes of the sinuses. Elder flower tea will lower a fever by producing a mild sweat. It combines nicely with equal parts catnip and peppermint to make a gentle fever tea for children. Add in yarrow to make a stronger tea for adults. The berries have strong antiviral activity and are best used as a tea, syrup or cordial for colds and flu.

Tradition? Yes! Innovation? Yes!

In Braucherei there is an inherent belief in the need for balance. This need is seen in the way that the Holy Trinity is balanced by the Three Sisters (the fates: maiden, mother, and crone). It is seen in the cross-gender transmission of the practice. The herbal healing traditions rely on this main tenet, striving to bring the body into a balanced state, keeping all four humors in check. Traditional agriculture recognizes this truth as well, by maintaining awareness of the surrounding environment, the movements of the stars, and the messages found in nature.

In this era all God's creatures face challenges that none before could have dreamed of. As human population continues to grow, as the climate is changing around us, we now walk the thinnest line between life and death for our species and for our earth. The imbalance we've cause has become self evident as severe storms and droughts intensify with each passing year, taking many in their fury.

We have heard the solutions, so simple, yet so difficult: change our way of life. Many have heeded this warning, and many more have ignored it, or worse scoffed at it, and fueled false media that combats this very evident truth. As we learn about Global warming, and the vast imbalance our society has created on the earth, perhaps we should turn to the resourceful and balanced traditions of the Pennsylvania Germans.

Traditional wisdom has proven its worth for centuries, teaching balance, awareness, and resourcefulness in all things. The Braucherei tradition has survived millennia of persecution, a most precious heirloom to be carefully passed on, polished, cherished, and passed on again. There is nothing like an heirloom. To see the edges worn soft by the care of so many hands, to know the promise that each generation passes to the next: "this will serve you well" they whisper down through time.

Tradition has served us well, but what of innovation? The Pennsylvania Germans are nothing if not tremendous innovators. In Medicine, Spirituality, Architecture, Agriculture, in commerce and trade; here is a culture that embraces both worlds: that of those who have gone before, and that of those who have yet to come.

PA German innovation has given us the beloved Pennsylvania

barn, banked into the hill for warmth, arranged to perform its tasks with the most efficiency. It has given us the crop rotation and contour farming that has become so much a part of modern farming- allowing farmers to conserve soil while also maximizing their yield. It has given us an openness to learning from native people of their medicine traditions, both herbal and spiritual, that this transplanted European people might learn to be in harmony in their new soil. Innovation has served us well.

Now is the time for both. Now is the time to claim our cultural inheritance, understand the wisdom of our elders, embrace it, and move past it as well. Now we must take the wisdom of the bank barn and incorporate it into living structures, to insulate, to design appropriately. Now is the time to transform agriculture into a system of production as well as healing for the ecosystem around us. Now we must transcend differences in medicine and allow science and tradition to walk hand in hand. Now is the time to find peace among ourselves, allow our many faiths to unite us instead of dividing us from each other.

The appropriate response to these warnings lies within each of us. Within our hearts, minds, and spirits we hold the tools and the power for change. As we look to traditional and indigenous culture we find a deep rooted wisdom, which has served all people for all time. It is from this deep well of tradition that we can draw to make our first steps into a sustainable future. We can learn to walk this path of wholeness, to make our elders proud of our efficiency and resourcefulness, and to be good elders ourselves, preparing the sustainable way for those unborn yet to be.



Calendar of Events

June 23rd 10-5 Sonnenwenden workshop

Pa German Cultural Heritage Center at Kutztown University

Come celebrate the apex of the creation cycle and the time of the first harvest. We will honor the balance of fire and water, growth and decline during this time of the summer solstice. Learn about the practice and evolution of traditional PA German Braucherei healing and spiritual practices

Optional seasonal Lunch using local organic ingredients -\$15

August 4th 10-5 Sommermit workshop

Pa German Cultural Heritage Center at Kutztown University

At Sommermit we celebrate the waning sun and the first grain harvest it has given us. Come learn about Braucherei traditions of this time, and how these practices can be applied to our lives in current times.

Optional Seasonal Lunch using local organic ingredients -\$15

*Guild Gatherings at Farm at Coventry 1333 Ridge Road Pottstown, PA 610-469-9591

May 26 : Braucherei Shamanic Techniques: Part1: Blanzeschwetze 10am to 3pm

Learn about shamanic techniques among the PA Germans. Part one of this program will focus on connecting with plant spirits to learn about their medicine. Learn about herbs ruled by Gemini. Plant swap in the afternoon.

June 30: Braucherei Shamanic Techniques: Part 2: Zeidschtrick 10am to 3pm

Learn about the PA German concept of a "Time Cord", and its use in healing practices. Learn to connect with your own time cord to heal wounds of the past or transform unhealthful patterns in the future. Learn about herbs ruled by Cancer.

July 28: Braucherei Shamanic Techniques: Part 3: Draume 10am to 3pm

Learn about PA German dream techniques, and herbs that promote dreaming. Discuss interpretation of dreams and other techniques for understanding dream messages. Learn about herbs ruled by Leo.

****Note:** Due to space restrictions the Guild Gatherings are pre-register events limited to 25, at this time Register early!

Please Print clearly!

Name

Address

Phone

email

To join the Hollerbier Haven Guild or to register for a gathering or workshop, please fill out the registration form completely and send along with a check or money order made payable to "Farm at Coventry"

Registration Form

		Optional Meal \$15	Member Price:	Non-Member
☐	Hollerbier Haven Annual Membership		\$25	
☐	May Guild Gathering May 26th	N/A	\$35	\$45
☐	Sonnenwenden Workshop June 23rd	Yes/No	\$35	\$45
☐	June Guild Gathering June 30th	N/A	\$35	\$45
☐	July Guild Gathering July 28th	N/A	\$35	\$45
☐	Sommermit Workshop August 4th	Yes/No	\$35	\$45
Send to: Farm at Coventry		For meals add \$15 per event		
1333 Ridge Rd		Grand Total		
Pottstown, PA 19465				

Questions? Call 610-469-9591 or email farmatcoventry@aol.com

Threë Sisters Center for the Healing Arts

In two locations:

Farm at Coventry

1333 Ridge Road

Pottstown, PA 19465

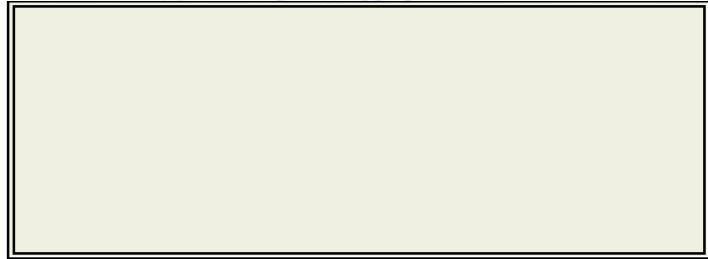
and

The Pennsylvania German

Cultural Heritage Center

22 Luckenbill Road

Kutztown, PA 19530



Phone: Jesse 484-336-4611

Fax 610-469-9510

E-mail: Thr3Sisters@AOL.com

Welcome to the Guild!

Welcome to the premier issue of our newsletter!! It is just a small taste of what is to come in future issues. We are continually learning new things about the Braucherei healing arts tradition and about the many aspects and uses of the healing herbs.

We hope you'll decide to join us in the Hollerbier Haven Herbal and Healing Arts Guild and that our newsletter, classes and Guild Gatherings will be a way for us to share this new knowledge and recovered wisdom with all of you! -Jesse and Susan

